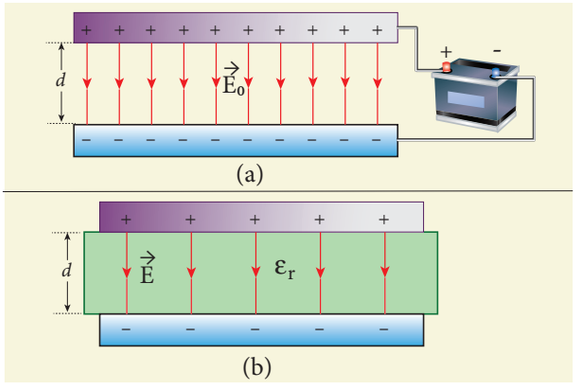


Figure 1.56 (a) Capacitor is charged with a battery (b) Dielectric is inserted after the battery is disconnected

The introduction of dielectric between the plates will decrease the electric field. Experimentally it is found that the modified electric field is given by

$$E = \frac{E_0}{\epsilon_r} \tag{1.91}$$

where E_o is the electric field inside the capacitors when there is no dielectric and ϵ_r is the relative permittivity of the dielectric or simply known as the dielectric constant. Since $\epsilon_r > 1$, the electric field $E < E_o$.

As a result, the electrostatic potential difference between the plates ($V = Ed$) is also reduced. But at the same time, the charge Q_o will remain constant once the battery is disconnected.

Hence the new potential difference is

$$V = Ed = \frac{E_0}{\epsilon_r} d = \frac{V_0}{\epsilon_r} \tag{1.92}$$

We know that capacitance is inversely proportional to the potential difference. Therefore as V decreases, C increases.

Thus new capacitance in the presence of a dielectric is

$$C = \frac{Q_0}{V} = \epsilon_r \frac{Q_0}{V_0} = \epsilon_r C_0 \tag{1.93}$$

Since $\epsilon_r > 1$, we have $C > C_o$. Thus insertion of the dielectric increases the capacitance.

Using equation (1.84),

$$C = \frac{\epsilon_r \epsilon_0 A}{d} = \frac{\epsilon A}{d} \tag{1.94}$$

where $\epsilon = \epsilon_r \epsilon_o$ is the permittivity of the dielectric medium.

The energy stored in the capacitor before the insertion of a dielectric is given by

$$U_0 = \frac{1}{2} \frac{Q_0^2}{C_0} \tag{1.95}$$

After the dielectric is inserted, the charge Q_0 remains constant but the capacitance is increased. As a result, the stored energy is decreased.

$$U = \frac{1}{2} \frac{Q_0^2}{C} = \frac{1}{2} \frac{Q_0^2}{\epsilon_r C_0} = \frac{U_0}{\epsilon_r} \tag{1.96}$$

Since $\epsilon_r > 1$ we get $U < U_o$. There is a decrease in energy because,when the dielectric is inserted, the capacitor spends some energy in pulling the dielectric inside.

(ii) When the battery remains connected to the capacitor

Let us now consider what happens when the battery of voltage V_0 remains connected to the capacitor when the dielectric is inserted into the capacitor. This is shown in Figure1.57.

The potential difference V_0 across the plates remains constant. But it is found experimentally (first shown by Faraday) that when dielectric is inserted, the charge stored in the capacitor is increased by a factor ϵ_r.

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